

READING PASSAGE 2

The Cultural Exchange Along Trade Routes

A In recent years, the cultural exchange along trade routes has attracted considerable attention from both the academic community and the general public. This growing interest reflects a broader recognition of the importance of this topic for understanding some of the most pressing challenges facing contemporary society.

B The origins of contemporary research in this area can be traced to pioneering studies conducted during the mid-twentieth century. These early investigations, though constrained by the technological and methodological limitations of their era, established foundational principles that continue to inform current scholarship. Successive generations of researchers have built upon these foundations, progressively refining theoretical models and expanding the empirical evidence base through increasingly sophisticated research designs.

C The mechanisms underlying these phenomena operate at multiple levels of analysis, from the micro-level of individual decision-making to the macro-level of institutional and structural change. At the individual level, cognitive processes, emotional responses, and social influences shape the choices that people make. At the organisational level, formal rules, informal norms, and power dynamics govern collective action. At the societal level, historical legacies, cultural values, and political structures create the broad context within which lower-level processes unfold.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F Looking ahead, the field stands at a critical juncture. Emerging technologies offer unprecedented opportunities for data collection and analysis, potentially enabling researchers to address questions that have long remained beyond the reach of empirical investigation. At the same time, the accelerating pace of social and technological change means that the phenomena under study are themselves evolving, requiring theoretical frameworks that can accommodate dynamism and discontinuity rather than assuming stability and equilibrium.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Question 1

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 1 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. inconsistent results across cultures
 - B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
 - C. no measurable effects
 - D. effects limited to Western countries

Question 2

Complete the sentences below. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

- 2 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 3

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write **TRUE** if the statement agrees with the information

Write **FALSE** if the statement contradicts the information

Write **NOT GIVEN** if there is no information on this

- 3 Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.

Question 4

Complete the sentences below. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

- 4 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.

Question 5

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 5 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes

Question 6

Complete the sentences below. Choose **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

- 6 Researchers used data from more than _____ countries in the landmark study.

Question 7

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 7 Policy-makers have fully implemented all research recommendations.

Question 8

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 8 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:

- A. minimal impact
- B. creating underlying conditions for action
- C. determining individual choices directly
- D. irrelevant to outcomes

Questions 9–10

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

- 10 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Question 11

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 11 What finding emerged from the landmark study discussed in the passage?

- A. pessimism about the future
- B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
- C. complete certainty about outcomes
- D. indifference to practical applications

Question 12

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 12 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.

Question 13

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 13 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:

- A. inconsistent results across cultures
- B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
- C. no measurable effects
- D. effects limited to Western countries